

The Cost of Perfection: Hidden Injustice And Inequality

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In *The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas* by Ursula K. Le Guin, a perfect society is presented that is built upon an uncomfortable moral dilemma. The people who live in Omelas experience transcending happiness, brilliance, and harmony, yet all of this is only able to remain perfect as long as one small child continues to suffer. If this child were to be set free, the entire society would no longer be the happy and perfect utopia the people want to continue living in will no longer exist. When people come to see the child, they either leave Omelas altogether for an unknown place, or they learn to live with the idea that a small child must suffer for their happiness. By looking at this text through a cultural and historical lens, supported by multiple sources, we can argue that this short story exposes the inequality behind certain social systems by revealing the dependence on hidden suffering, the normalization of that suffering, and the results of individual resistance. This suggests that the story is not just a utopian narrative with fantasy aspects, but reveals a deeper meaning on societal structures, reflecting real-world systems of inequality and injustice.

Le Guin tackles the idea of a world that is sustained and thrives only because of the suffering of an innocent child, which in turn reflects cultural concerns about inequality and corruption within modern economic and financial systems. One specific scholarly article also supports this claim, suggesting that a common characteristic of utopian or “perfect” societies is that they hide, justify, and ignore “profound inequalities” produced by economic systems (Fitting). An example of this kind of inequality can be seen during the Industrial Revolution. During this time, while many people were gaining jobs and building companies, child labor became common in these growing industries. Companies operated under conditions that included

“long hours, lack of safety codes, and paying less to children,” while continuing to profit from the unfair treatment of these workers (History.com). These systems relied on hidden suffering that was often ignored or justified as necessary for economic growth. This situation mirrors Omelas, which maintains a sense of happiness and bliss while depending on the deeper injustice of a child’s suffering.

This child's suffering within the systematic society of Omelas functions as an example of exploitation and mirrors a societal construct about how pain sustains the comfort of others. The speaker of this story tells the reader that “they all know it is there,” meaning that the whole community of Omelas is highly aware of the fact that their perfect society is only able to succeed on the back of a suffering child (Le Guin). Furthermore, even though they are all aware, they have come to accept this reality and find normalcy within it. This reflects a very popular cultural phenomenon called utilitarianism. Utilitarian philosophy focuses on the idea that an “action is morally acceptable if it maximizes the well-being of the greatest number of people” (Batres). This appears to be one of the key moral dilemmas throughout the story: is it justifiable to choose to sacrifice one for the benefit of the whole? In the story, the answer in Omelas is obviously yes, because the citizens of this community convince themselves that the child’s suffering is necessary for the benefit of their society. Through this cultural lens, the story reveals how societies defend the manipulation and suffering of the child through the idea that it is essential for the happiness and perfection of their society.

Also within this story, one of the most striking reactions of the people of Omelas is not related to the child’s hidden suffering, but rather the community's willingness to accept it. Although the narrator at first describes people's reactions as being full of “anger, outrage, and impotence,” they eventually come to the idea that the boy's abuse is justified (Le Guin). This is

further highlighted when “their tears at the bitter injustice dry when they begin to perceive the terrible justice of reality” (Le Guin). This strong shift in tension, from moral questioning and outrage to acceptance of inequality, reflects real-world patterns of complicity, in which people come to tolerate systemic injustice because they are not experiencing it themselves. This is similar to a psychological phenomenon called the bystander effect, which is when “the greater the number of people present, the less likely any individual is to step in” to help (Thriveworks). This creates a cultural situation in which people believe that if no one else is doing anything to change an injustice or inequality, it must be acceptable not to act as well. This is directly reflected in Omelas, where the people do not make any decision to help the child, even though they are all highly aware that the child is in need of help. Overall, through this specific cultural lens, the story expresses why communities lack action in helping the suffering child, as they remain with the rest of the bystanders, not wanting to stand out.

Le Guin gives the readers something else to think about when the narrator reveals that some individuals choose to walk away from the Omelas representing a form of disagreement with the child's suffering. These specific individuals are said to “leave Omelas, they walk ahead into the darkness, and they do not come back,” completely refusing the community of Omelas altogether, but it is also important to note that these individuals do not attempt to free the child or change the system (Le Guin). This suggests a cultural idea that while people are able to refuse and deny participating in an inequality, they also don't try to change it. This is similar to the idea of avoidance, which is a coping mechanism that allows you to “run away from problems in order to avoid them altogether” leaving them unresolved (South Coast Counselors and Physicians). This creates a real world situation where when people tend to go through high stressful situations or decisions they tend to avoid them altogether to prevent making a decision that would cause

them more stress than if they did nothing but run away. This coping mechanism is very much present within the individuals in this story that decide to simply leave instead of trying to help in any way possible. Ultimately through his lens, this situation reveals that when it comes to high stress situations individuals might tend to lean toward not helping at all but find it easier to escape the situation altogether.

To conclude, within the short story *The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas*, Ursula K. Le Guin uses cultural and historical influences to reveal the injustice and inequality behind specific social systems by showing the dependence on hidden suffering, the normalization of that suffering, and the results of individual resistance. Specific lenses within cultural and historical studies that we can use to highlight these meanings of interpretation include utilitarianism, the bystander effect, avoidance, and the historical context of the Industrial Revolution. By connecting the story to real-world structures, Le Guin challenges readers to confront the moral cost of their own comfort. This story suggests that awareness alone is not enough, but that true moral responsibility requires action, even when that action is difficult.

Work Cited

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